

33 East 17th Street

The Century Building: An Ode in Brick and Stone — A Poetic Meditation on 33 East 17th Street

Every previously italicized phrase is highlighted and colour-coded by source. Where the source page is on file, clicking the highlight opens the scan.

COLOUR KEY — ONE COLOUR PER SOURCE · sources with a page scan are marked ↗

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| ■ Egan, <i>Pop Culture New York City</i> , 2018 p. 124 (1) ↗ | ■ Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016 p. 291 (16) ↗ |
| ■ Unknown Author, <i>Landmarks Preservation Commission</i> p. 1 (1) ↗ | ■ AIA, <i>AIA Edition 3</i> , 1988 p. 186 (5) ↗ |
| ■ Morrone, <i>Architectural Guidebook</i> , 1994 p. 116 (5) ↗ | ■ LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881 p. 1 (32) ↗ |
| ■ Greene, <i>New York for New Yorkers</i> , 2001 p. 32 (3) ↗ | ■ Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009 p. 76 (4) ↗ |
| ■ Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i> , 2020 p. 96 (7) ↗ | ■ Stern, <i>New York 2000</i> , 2006 pp. 377, 1140 (6) ↗ |
| ■ Byron, <i>New York Interiors At the Turn of the Century</i> , 1976 p. 154 (1) ↗ | ■ Stern, <i>New York 1880</i> , 1999 pp. 440, 442 (2) ↗ |
| ■ G W Bromley & Co, <i>1916 Atlas of the Borough of Manhattan</i> p. 55 (1) ↗ | ■ Dripps, <i>1867 Dripps Plan</i> p. 7 (1) ↗ |
| ■ Goldberger, <i>The City Observed</i> , 1979 p. 91 (2) ↗ | |

AUDIO — 33 EAST 17TH STREET | BRICK CAKE (POETIC) 14 min 22 s

Audio track — playable in the HTML version of this document.

I. INVOCATION

Upon the northern brow of Union Square, where the old city keeps its restless watch, there stands a keeper of forgotten air — a thing of brick, a lantern, and a latch. It fronts the world at (33 East 17th Street), and turns its shoulders toward (East 18th Street) behind, a double-hearted stone where two eras meet, one face for pomp, one face content to hide. It (Was built in 1881.) — that solemn year — by one whose name the mortar still repeats: the hand of (William Schickel), patient, clear, who taught cold masonry to sing in the streets. And though the world would call it, by and by, (BARNES & NOBLE, FORMERLY CENTURY BUILDING) — still it wears that name the way a widow wears the sky, serene above the rush of thoroughfares. It stands where guides have placed it, plain and true, (33 East 17th St., bet. Park Ave. S. and Broadway to W. 18th St.), and dreamers swear this (red-brick-and-limestone Queen Anne pile comes straight out of Victorian London), come to woo.

II. OF STYLE, AND THE GHOST OF AN AGE

What language does this quiet giant speak? Its tongue is set in record, terse and grand: *(Queen-Anne, neo-Grec: Secondary Façade 18th Street)* — the meek back-face and the proud front, hand in hand. It is a mood *(distinguished by its picturesque mixture of seventeenth- and eighteenth-century English motifs)*, a marriage of the centuries, gently wed; and though the classic order guards its griefs, *(Although classical details are commonly used (such as the Jacobean doorway), these are combined in an unusual and thoroughly nonclassical way.)* It carries in its bones a movement's fire, for it was *(Championed by such artists and writers as James McNeill Whistler and Oscar Wilde, the Queen Anne style developed along with the English Aesthetic movement.)*

Rare bloom! For history is quick to boast: *(The Century Building is one of the few surviving commercial examples of the Queen Anne style in the city)* — *(one of the few extant major Queen Anne buildings in Manhattan)*, a near-vanished ghost, since *(Queen Anne-style commercial buildings are rare in NYC.)*, more's the pity. The scholars nod: *(The red brick Century Building is a rare New York example of a Queen Anne- style commercial structure.)* And why this daring dress upon a trade? Because *(William Schickel might have used the Queen Anne style, which was common in domestic suburban designs but almost unknown in urban commercial structures, to draw attention to what was essentially a speculative office building.)* For *(The Union Square area was booming in the last quarter of the nineteenth century. Unusual or distinctive building design would have been one way of appealing to potential tenants, especially those who thought themselves socially or artistically progressive.)* It keeps rare cousins, kin of stone and dawn — the *(Gramercy apartments (1883. G. W da Cunha, 8.7) at Gramercy Park)*, and, southward, the *(former Mercantile Exchange (1884, Thomas R. Jackson, 3.12) in TriBeCa.)*

III. THE BODY OF COLOR

Behold the flesh of it — a painter's psalm, a warmth of clay against a cooler grace: it wears its *(Warm red brick, crisp bluestone trim)*, its calm, the flush and pallor of a living face. The ledgers hold its very hue in trust — *(Façade Color_Brick Red - 196 47 69)* — the deep, and, at the foot, a pale and crystal dust: *(Base Color_Crystal - 213 213 213)*, the low notes that it keeps. Its courses run in ordered, patient rhyme, a *(Running Bond)* of brick on brick on brick, its edges hemmed in *(Wyoming Bluestone)*'s time, and men have called it — tender, half in love — a *(red brick and whitestone charmer)*, warm and quick. The whole is spun of *(Brick, Terra Cotta, Wyoming Bluestone, Iron)*, its base of *(Red Brick, Wyoming Bluestone)* — earth and air — a fabric raised, the record's soft environ, *(to house the prestigious Century Publishing Company)* there. And on the wall, refusing to lie flat, rise *(Rusticated Brick Pilasters)*, proud and tall — the building draws itself up, tips its hat, and stands a little grander for it all.

IV. THE FACE, READ FEATURE BY FEATURE

The Door

The entrance opens like a spoken vow, a (3 Bays) measure, ceremonious, wide; it is at once both (Pedimented) and low-(Arched), its brow crowned with a (Fanlight), letting morning inside. Its (Tuscan Pilasters) stand like faithful men, and, quaint upon their heads — a whimsy sweet — a (Console Bracket Capital) blooms again, while (Cast Iron Ornament) guards the threshold's seat. For (crisply carved stone surround the ground floor entrance.), and through the (Jacobean doorway) step the years.

The Window That Leans Toward the World

Now see the marvel of its middle grace, a (2-story Oriel) thrust into the light — this is the tender miracle of place, for that (two-story oriel window give this Queen Anne style commercial building a welcoming domestic aspect.), warm and bright. It is a hallmark, sung in learned tone: (The tall oriel window, gambrel roof, prominent chimneys, and molded terra cotta ornament are all characteristic of the style.) Above, the panes rise gently, arch on arch, a (Segmental Arch Lintel (3-5)) curved like a bow, each one capped proudly on its upward march by one bright (Stone Keystone), holding it just so. And through the glass — a lattice, luminous, thin — the (Window Panes: [1/1] (w/ Transom)) let the daylight in.

The Carven Feast

O what a garden blooms upon this height, where clay was coaxed to flower and to face! For (Richly detailed terra-cotta panels and crisply carved stone surround the ground floor entrance, embellish the facade, and reappear in the treatment of the top floor dormers.) Its vocabulary is a wreathèd art — (Garlands, Shells, Grotesques), and, hung in fold on fold, the draped sweetness of its (Swags), apart, disciplined by a (Dentil Course)'s ranks of gold, and by an (Egg & Dart Course), that ancient rhyme — for it is (characteristic of the finest Queen Anne design in its free use of classical motifs in stone and terracotta and its employment of the style's trademark sunflowers.) And highest, brightest, reaching for the sun, the (Sunflower Terra Cotta Finials), one by one.

The Crown

The roof leans back in a (Gambrel Roof)'s embrace, and out of it, like watchmen, boldly climb the (2-Story Dormers), keeping their high place, the (prominent chimneys) measuring the time. A (Cast Iron Cornice) binds the wall to sky, with (Dentils), and a (Frieze), and — canted, bold — the (Skew Corbels) that hold the slope on high, a (Balustrade) to hem it, fold in fold, and last, forever lifting up their eyes, the (Sunflower Terra Cotta Finials) greet the skies.

V. THE CHAMBERED HEART

Within, the building keeps its inward light, its *(high ceilings and such architectural features as Corinthian capped cast-iron columns and consider able original woodwork)*; and in its later, gentler, bookish night it *(featured a college library-like study hall with rows of tables overlooking Broadway attracting students and others.)* But long before the readers came to browse, another order ruled these solemn floors: *(The labyrinth of banistered corrals provided well-defined spaces for executives and employees, and it symbolized a well ordered bureaucracy. The pilastered screen with leaded colored-glass windows further departmentalized the workers. Electricity has been brought down to the desk lamps.)*

VI. THE LONG PROCESSION OF THE YEARS

It rose from dream and daring, coin and hope — *(developed as a speculative venture by the dry-goods company Arnold Constable)* — for *(The Century Building was commissioned as a speculative undertaking by the Arnold and Constable families. In addition to their department store, they were among the largest landholders in late nineteenth-century New York.)* It took its name from words, from printed leaf: *(The building takes its name from the Century Company, publishers of The Century Magazine and St. Nicholas Magazine, which had offices there.)* There lived *(the popular Century magazine (for grown-ups) and St. Nicholas (for boys and girls))*, and greatness passed its threshold, page on page, for *(The Century was a noted literary publication, carrying work by Mark Twain, Henry James, Walt Whitman, and Herman Melville)*, and it held, too, *(books by Edith Wharton, Mark Twain, and Rudyard Kipling.)* The maps recall it, faithful and precise — *(1 Structure; 6 Story Brick building with Store and Elevators)* — plain, and, counting up the dormers toward the ice of winter sky, it climbs a *(seven-story)* reign. Before it stood, another name held sway upon this ground, in eighteen-sixty-seven's dark: the vanished *(Everett House)* has slipped away.

VII. THE SECOND LIFE

Then came the silence, and then came the mend: *(After standing vacant for many years, the braiding was converted into a bookstore, and the facade received an award-winning restoration.)* For it was blessed, and set beyond the end, *(DESIGNATED: OCTOBER 7, 1986)* — a nation's veneration. And so, in time, the great rebirth occurred: *(In 1995 Barnes & Noble transformed the 100,000-square-foot Queen Anne-style Century Building.)* For loving hands returned it, stone and word — *(Judith Saltzman of Li-Saltzman restored the facade, and James Cohen was charged with maintaining the character of the landmark interiors, which were listed on the National Register.)* And yet the poets grieved a subtler cost, that *(effect was impressive, even though it lacked the intimacy and charm of many of the traditional bookstores such as Shakespeare Company and Endicott that the superstores were rapidly driving out of business.)*

VIII. AMONG ITS KINDRED

It never stood alone upon its ground, but kept its neighbors close, a stately row, its portrait, once, in company was found — *(showing, from left to right the Parish Building (Detlef Lienau, 1883 – 1884), Century Company Building, and Everett house (1854).)* It waits, the record says, without a sound, *(across the street on the south corner of 17th Street facing Union Square.)* And when the city moved to save its own, its name was writ among the guarded few: *(Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1-3 Union Square West; the Bank of the Metropolis (Bruce Price, 1903), 31 Union Square West; the Century Building (William Schickel, 1881), 33 East Seventeenth Street; the Everett Building (Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), 45 East Seventeenth Street; and the Germania Life Insurance Company Building (D'Oench & Yost, 1911), later the Guardian Life Building, 50 Union Square East.)*

Not all who passed adored it. One would frown — one voice that found it out of key, and swore *(the Queen Anne pile might have worked somewhere else, it seems oddly uncomfortable here. Union Square can accommodate flamboyant show-offs and it can accommodate derelicts, but not genteel matrons.)*

IX. BENEDICTION

So let it stand, this gentle, gabled thing, whose *(Warm red brick, crisp bluestone trim, and a two-story oriel window give this Queen Anne style commercial building a welcoming domestic aspect)*, whose *(Richly detailed terra-cotta panels and crisply carved stone)* still sing long after those who raised them fell to rest. For it endures — the record's final word — *(one of the few surviving commercial examples of the Queen Anne style in the city)*, and by the hands of *(Li/Saltzman Architects)* restored, this *(red brick and whitestone charmer)* keeps its pity and pride together, sunflowers still crowned, this *(Queen Anne pile)* upon its patch of ground.



CITATION CHART

Every highlighted quote, in order of appearance, correlated to its underlying source. The swatch matches the highlight colour in the text.

I. Invocation

#	Verbatim Quote (abbreviated)	Source (Author, Title, Year, Page)
1	"33 East 17th Street"	 Egan, <i>Pop Culture New York City</i> , 2018, p. 124 [page scan]
2	"East 18th Street"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 291 [page scan]
3	"Was built in 1881."	 Unknown Author, <i>Landmarks Preservation Commission</i> , p. 1 [page scan]
4	"William Schickel"	 AIA, <i>AIA Edition 3</i> , 1988, p. 186 [page scan]
5	"BARNES & NOBLE, FORMERLY CENTURY BUILDING"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 291 [page scan]
6	"33 East 17th St., bet. Park Ave. S. and Broadway to W. 18th St."	 AIA, <i>AIA Edition 3</i> , 1988, p. 186 [page scan]
7	"red-brick-and-limestone Queen Anne pile comes straight out of Victorian London"	 Morrone, <i>Architectural Guidebook</i> , 1994, p. 116 [page scan]

II. Of Style, and the Ghost of an Age

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9	"distinguished by its picturesque mixture of seventeenth- and eighteenth-century English motifs"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 291 [page scan]
10	"Although classical details are commonly used (such as the Jacobean doorway), these are combined in an unusual and thoroughly nonclassical way."	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 291 [page scan]
11	"Championed by such artists and writers as James McNeill Whistler and Oscar Wilde, the Queen Anne style developed along with the English Aesthetic movement."	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 291 [page scan]
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17	"The Union Square area was booming in the last quarter of the nineteenth century. Unusual or distinctive building design would have been one way of appealing to potential..."	Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 291 [page scan]
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III. The Body of Color

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20	"Warm red brick, crisp bluestone trim"	Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i> , 2020, p. 96 [page scan]
21	"Façade Color_Brick Red - 196 47 69"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
22	"Base Color_Crystal - 213 213 213"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
23	"Running Bond"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
24	"Wyoming Bluestone"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
25	"red brick and whitestone charmer"	AIA, <i>AIA Edition 3</i> , 1988, p. 186 [page scan]
26	"Brick, Terra Cotta, Wyoming Bluestone, Iron"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
27	"Red Brick, Wyoming Bluestone"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
28	"to house the prestigious Century Publishing Company"	Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009, p. 76 [page scan]
29	"Rusticated Brick Pilasters"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]

The Door

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30	"3 Bays"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
31	"Pedimented"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
32	"Arched"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
33	"Fanlight"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
34	"Tuscan Pilasters"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
35	"Console Bracket Capital"	LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]

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36	"Cast Iron Ornament"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
37	"crisply carved stone surround the ground floor entrance."	 Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i> , 2020, p. 96 [page scan]
38	"Jacobean doorway"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 291 [page scan]

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39	"2-story Oriel"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
40	"two-story oriel window give this Queen Anne style commercial building a welcoming domestic aspect."	 Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i> , 2020, p. 96 [page scan]
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42	"Segmental Arch Lintel (3-5)"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
43	"Stone Keystone"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
44	"Window Panes: [1/1] (w/ Transom)"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]

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48	"Dentil Course"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
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52	"Gambrel Roof"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
53	"2-Story Dormers"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]

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54	"prominent chimneys"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 291 [page scan]
55	"Cast Iron Cornice"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
56	"Dentils"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
57	"Frieze"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
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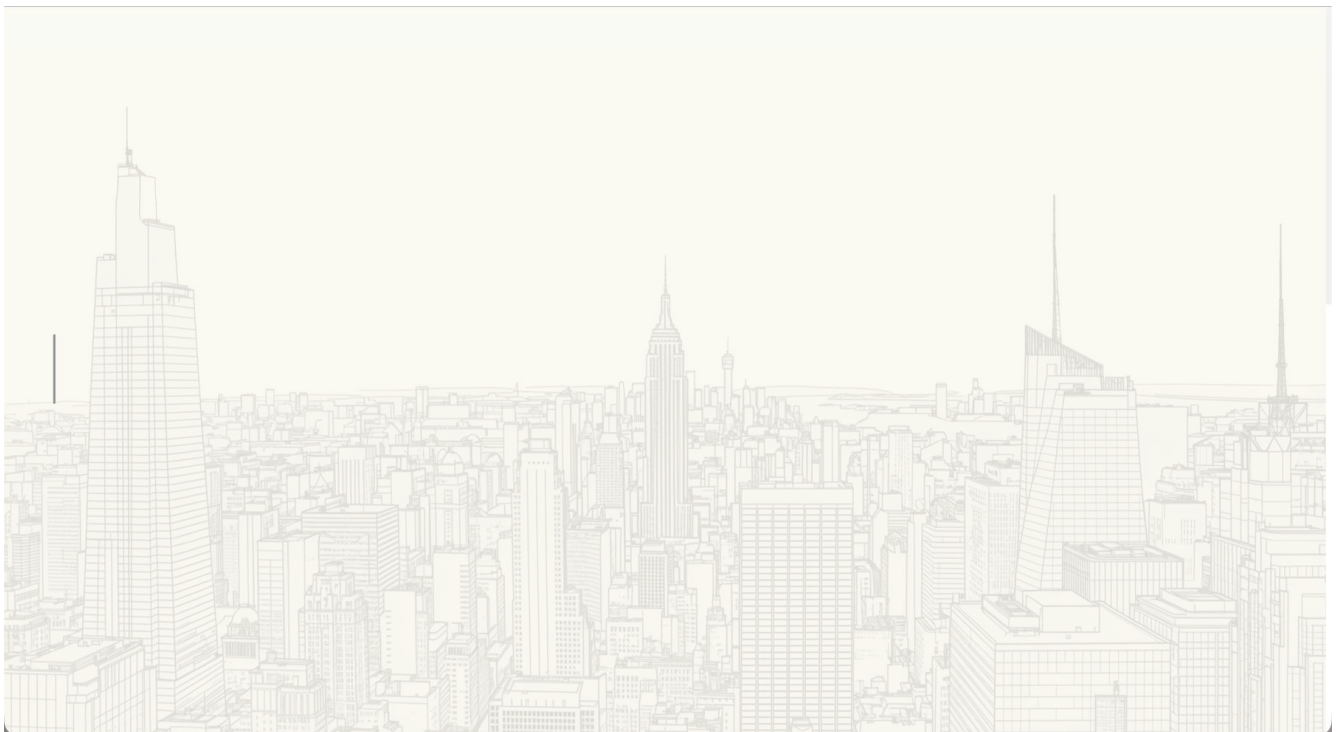
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78	"showing, from left to right the Parish Building (Detlef Lienau, 1883 – 1884), Century Company Building, and Everett house (1854)."	 Stern, <i>New York 1880</i> , 1999, p. 440 [page scan]
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IX. Benediction

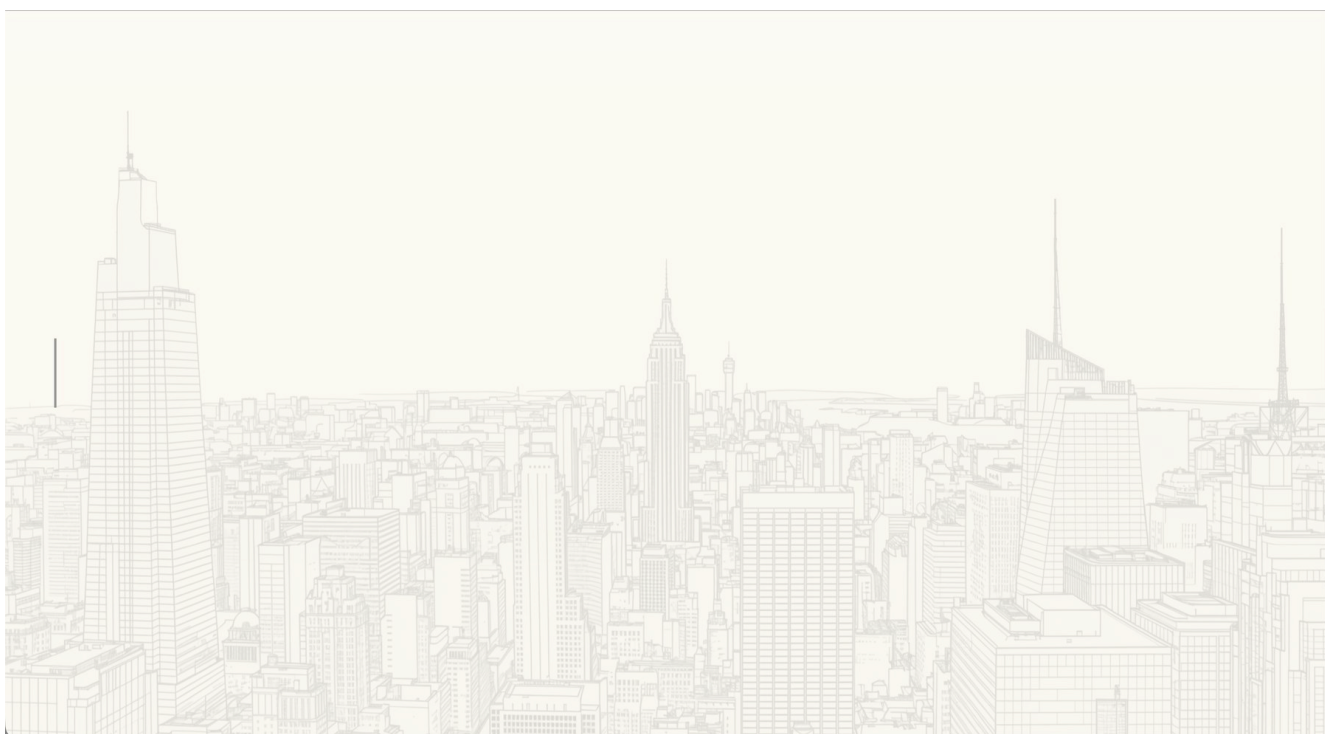
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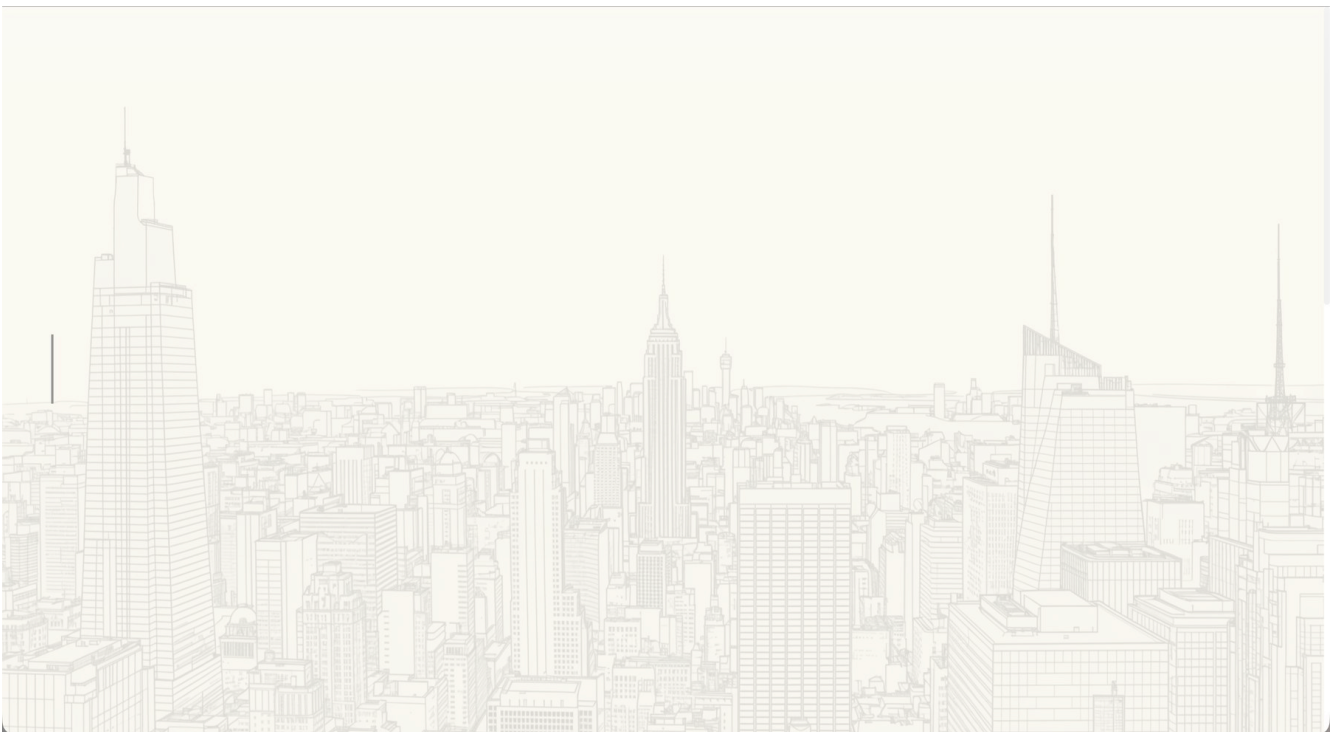
SOURCE PAGES

17 scanned pages, one per cited source page. Each lists the highlighted quotes drawn from it.



Egan, *Pop Culture New York City*, 2018, p. 124

Quotes drawn from this page: 1



BOOKSTORES

Large chain bookstores: Manhattan

Barnes and Noble, Upper West Side: 2289 Broadway at 82nd Street, Upper West Side. barnesandnoble.com

Barnes and Noble, Upper East Side: 150 East 86th Street near Lexington Avenue, Upper East Side

Barnes and Noble, Citigroup: 160 East 54th Street at 3rd Avenue, Midtown East

Barnes and Noble, Fifth Avenue: 555 Fifth Avenue at 46th Street, Midtown East

Barnes and Noble, Tribeca: 97 Warren Street at Greenwich Avenue, Tribeca

Barnes and Noble, Union Square: 33 East 17th Street near Broadway, Flatiron

Barnes and Noble, Columbia University Bookstore: 2922 Broadway at 116th Street, Upper West Side

Amazon Bookstore: Time Warner Center, 10 Columbus Circle at 59th Street and Broadway, Upper West Side

Amazon Bookstore: 7 West 34th Street between 5th and 6th Avenues, Midtown South

Independent, General Book Stores: Manhattan

Book Culture: 536 West 112th Street near Broadway, Upper West Side (Morningside Heights). bookculture.com. Main store. General and scholarly books. New and used. Some textbooks. Near Columbia University.

Book Culture: 2915 Broadway at West 114th Street, Upper West Side (Morningside Heights). Neighborhood store. General books and gifts.

Book Culture on Columbus: 450 Columbus Avenue near 82nd Street, Upper West Side. General books and gifts.

Bookbook: 266 Bleecker Street near Morton Street, Greenwich Village. bookbooknyc.com. General book shop, emphasis on fiction/literature.

The Corner Bookstore: 1313 Madison Avenue at 93rd Street, Upper East Side. cornerbookstorenyc.com. Specializes in bestsellers, children's, and travel books.

Crawford Doyle Booksellers: 1082 Madison Avenue at 81st Street, Upper East Side. crawforddoyle.com

McNally Jackson: 52 Prince Street near Mulberry Street, Soho. mcnallyjackson.com. Coffee, new releases, book printing machine for books on demand.

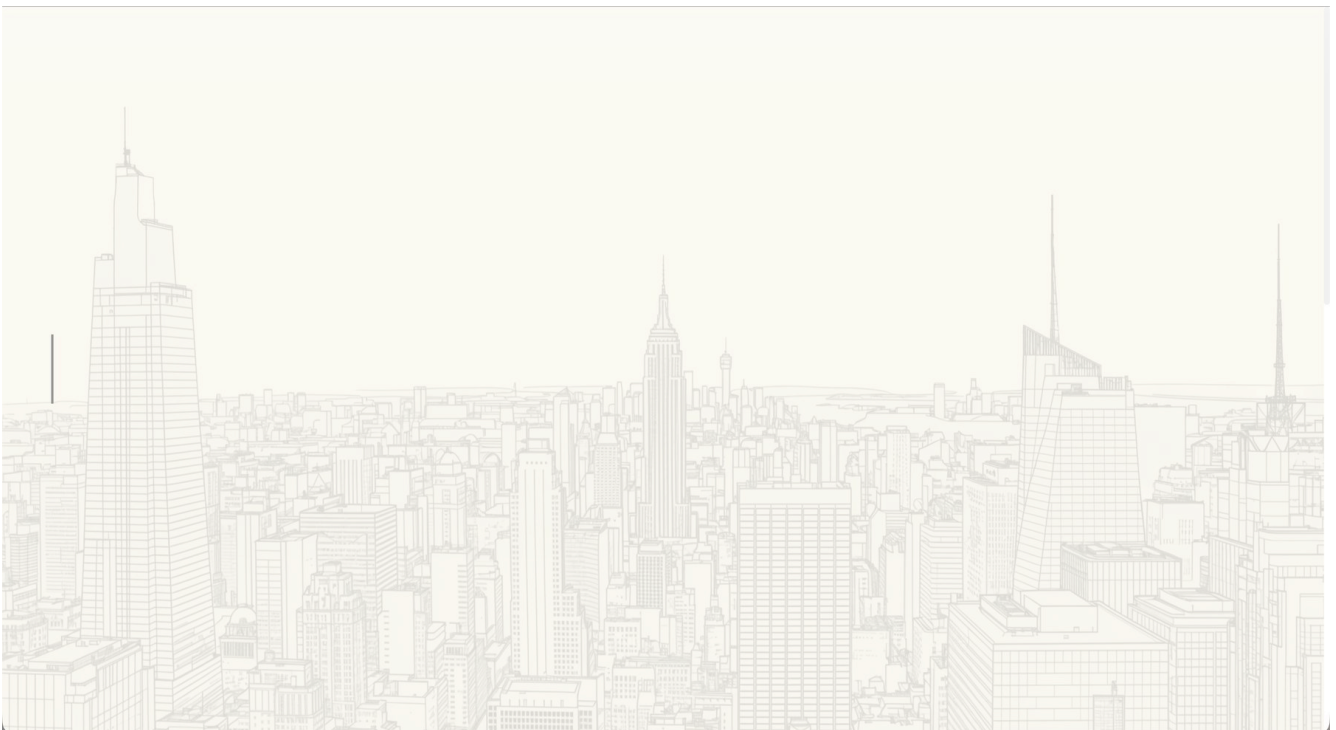
New York University Bookstore: 726 Broadway at Waverly Place, East Village. bookstores.nyu.edu. General books, textbooks, and gifts

Posman Books in Chelsea Market: 75 Ninth Avenue, Chelsea. posman-books.com. General neighborhood-style bookstore.

Posman Books in Rockefeller Center: 30 Rockefeller Plaza (concourse) near West 50th Street, Midtown West. posmanbooks.com. General neighborhood-style bookstore.

Spielvogel, *The Landmarks of New York*, 2016, p. 291

Quotes drawn from this page: 2 5 9 10 11 12 16 17 38 41 54 66 68 74 84 85





JOHN H. AND ELIZABETH J. ELSWORTH HOUSE

cornices, are surrounded by distinctive molding. The central second floor window on the front façade is topped with a pediment, while the roofline cornice, divided by S-curve brackets and decorated with rectangular molds, is topped with a central segmental pediment dramatically elaborated with a bull's-eye detail.

After the Elsworths lived in the house for 39 years, it was sold to a succession of owners. The most notable was jazz guitarist Chuck Wayne, who lived in the house from 1961 to 1991. That year, Russell Powell, a restoration carpenter and president of Island Housewrights Corporation, purchased the property. Powell is the current owner of the property, and has completed a full restoration.

THE WINDERMERE

1880–81; 2015–

400–406 WEST 57TH STREET (869

NINTH AVENUE AND 871–877 NINTH AVENUE), MANHATTAN

ARCHITECT: THEOPHILUS G. SMITH; MORRIS ADJM ARCHITECTS

DESIGNATED: JUNE 28, 2005

The Windermere is the oldest large apartment complex in Manhattan's oldest apartment house district. Composed of three seven-story buildings in Midtown West, it is notable as one of the first residences in the city to offer housing to single women in the late nineteenth century.

Architect Theophilus Smith drew upon a variety of architectural styles often employed in New York City rowhouses to construct the Windermere, including the Queen Anne style—articulated in the textured corbelled and multicolored Philadelphia brickwork, and the Romanesque Revival style—apparent in the arched windows and rotund shapes of the building's cornices. The three distinct buildings unite to form a cohesive façade, utilizing similar features and themes, but are differentiated on the 57th Street façade by brick pilasters. The buildings all display sizable brick cornices and stone cymatium molding. Notably, each of the buildings features unique fenestration and massing. The structures present dog-toothed brick along the roof line, which is organized into horizontal and soldier courses to offer additional visual interest.

By 1910, the residence had lost many tenants due to the construction of the subway, which rendered other locations more desirable. Over the next 50 years, its rooms were inhabited by artists, including photographer Alonzo Hanagan and actor Steve McQueen.

During the 1970s, the Windermere experienced significant landlord and tenant conflict. Following decades of neglect, the Landmarks Preservation Commission initiated a lawsuit against



THE WINDERMERE

the Tokyo-based owner, which required the agency to consult with the U.S. State Department. In May 2009, the owner agreed to pay a record \$1.1 million in fines, and to sell the Windermere. In 2013, the Landmarks Preservation Commission unanimously approved a proposal by the current owner to construct a rooftop addition, install a new storefront, change the use of the complex from a residence to a hotel, and restore the façade. As of 2015, the building was undergoing renovation, and covered with scaffolding.

BARNES & NOBLE, FORMERLY CENTURY BUILDING

1880–81; 1994–95

33 EAST 17TH STREET AND 38–46 EAST 18TH STREET, MANHATTAN

ARCHITECTS: WILLIAM SCHICKEL; LI/SALTZMAN ARCHITECTS

DESIGNATED: OCTOBER 7, 1986

The Century Building is one of the few surviving commercial examples of the Queen Anne style in the city.

Unknown Author, *Landmarks Preservation Commission*, p. 1

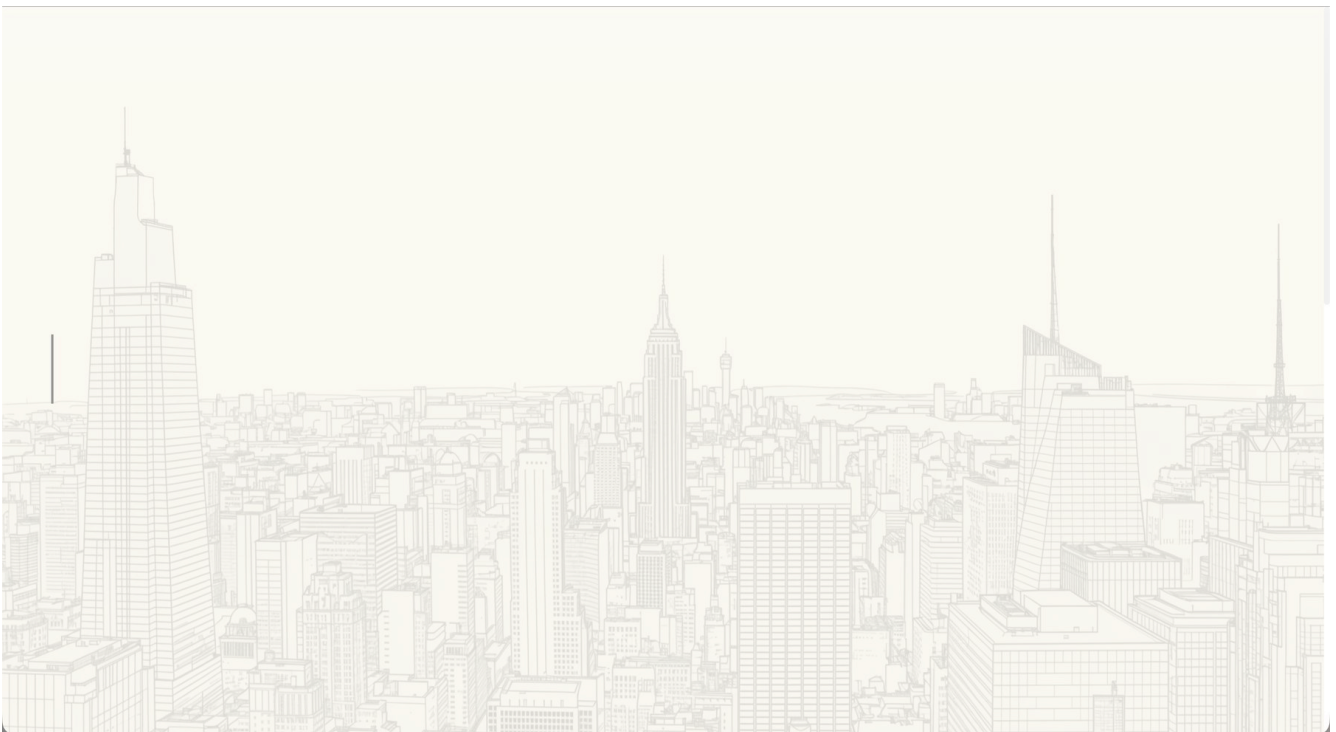
Quotes drawn from this page: 3 · Citation record supplied in place of the page image.

“Was built in 1881.”

- LANDMARKS PRESERVATION COMMISSION · 1881
- P. 1

Mentioned as: “33 East 17th Street”

[View Document Image](#)



AIA, *AIA Edition 3*, 1988, p. 186

Quotes drawn from this page: 4 6 25 67 86





[W 3.] **American Savings Bank/originally Union Square Savings Bank**, 20 Union Sq. E., NE cor. E. 15th St. 1924. Henry Bacon.

A classy **Corinthian colonnade** is somewhat forlorn in these precincts. **Bacon's** best remembrance is the **Lincoln Memorial**.



[W 4a.] **Guardian Life Insurance Company/originally Germania Life Insurance Company**, 201 Park Ave. S., NE cor. E. 17th St. 1911. D'Oench & Yost. [W 4b.] **Annex**, 105 E. 17th St., bet. Park Ave. S. and Irving Place. 1961. Skidmore, Owings & Merrill.

The **mansarded** bulk of this **Renaissance Revival** marvel is best seen from a distance, down 17th Street or from the adjacent Union Square Park. **Germania Life** was a name that became an onerous millstone at the advent of World War I. The board of directors agreed to rename it, picking a name with the largest number of reusable letters that they could find. **Guardian** still crowns the roof against its mansard backdrop.

Next door is the sleek annex, a simple grid of **aluminum and glass** infilled behind with white vertical blinds. As an accessory, it is a graceful annex to the proud parent, unabashedly "modern," an articulated annex.



[W 2.] Zeckendorf Towers (apts.)



[W 5.] Century Building at Union Sq.



[W 5.] Originally **The Century Building**, 33 E. 17th St., bet. Park Ave. S. and Broadway to W. 18th St. 1881. William Schickel. ★

This red brick and whitestone charmer is where the popular Cen-

tury magazine (for grown-ups) and **St. Nicholas** (for boys and girls) were published before the century turned.

[W 6.] 31 Union Square West/originally Bank of the Metropolis Building, NW cor. 16th St. 1903. Bruce Price.

An early and unwitting **sliver building**, this neo-Renaissance slab now houses a restaurant in its original banking rooms, a place for **SUPERMAN'S** lunch.

[W 7.] Originally Lincoln Building, 1 Union Sq. W., NW cor. E. 14th St. 1890. R. H. Robertson

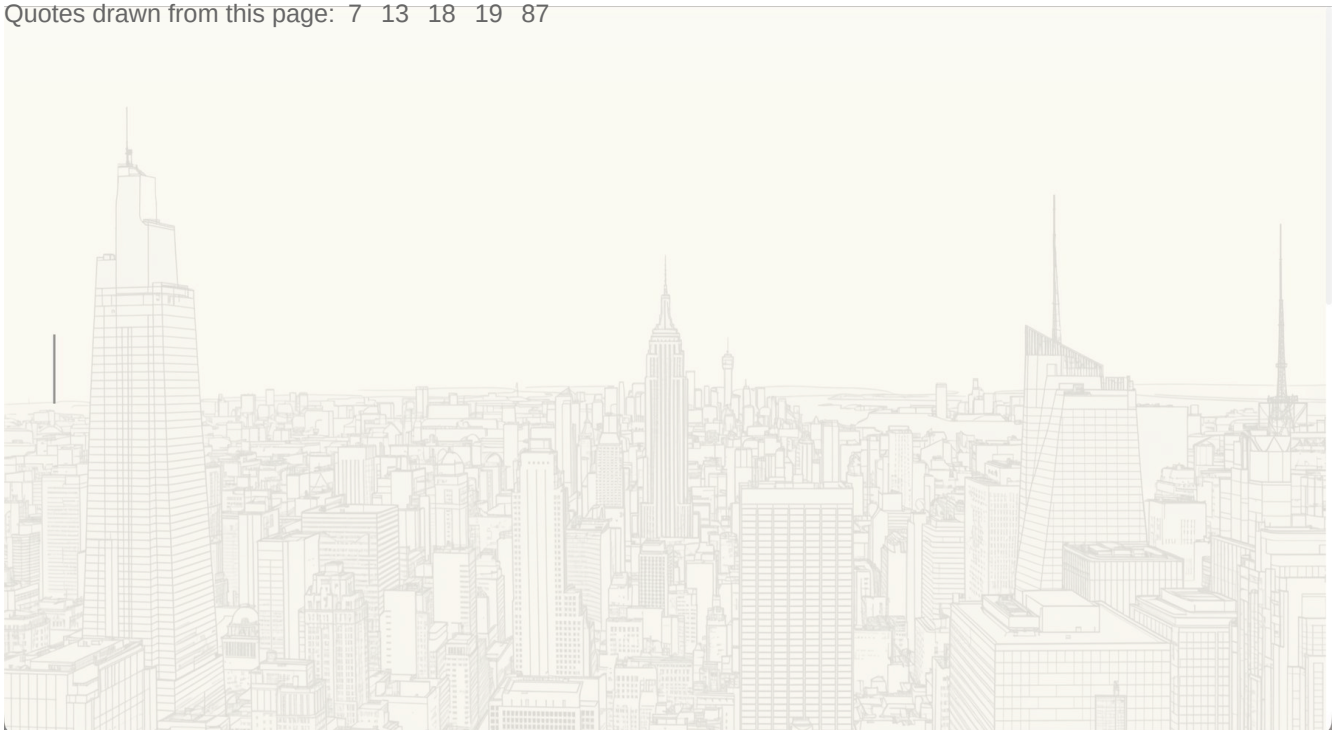
Romanesque Revival granite crowned with a cornice of 40 little windows with interstitial paired columns.

[W 8.] Originally YWCA (Young Women's Christian Association)/formerly Rand School, 7 E. 15th St., bet. Union Sq. W. and Fifth Ave. ca. 1889. R. H. Robertson.

Romanesque Revival in granite, brick, and brownstone. The grand bay windows give the entrance portal a stronger stature.



[W 9a.] Sidney Hillman Health Center/originally Margaret Louisa Home, YWCA (lodging house), 16 E. 16th St., bet. Union Sq. W. and Fifth Ave. 1890. R. H. Robertson.



14th and 15th streets. Designed by Davis, Brody & Associates and built in 1987, this massive apartment and office complex represents the most strenuous effort to date to gentrify the neighborhood. The basic ungentrifiability of Union Square, however, is verified by the fact that Zeckendorf Towers turns its back on the square and places its main entrance around the block on the relatively tranquil and attractive Irving Place. The quartet of illuminated pyramids that top Zeckendorf Towers have become a conspicuous skyline feature, and sadly block the uptown view of the lighted clock face of the **Consolidated Edison Building** across the street at Four Irving Place, an ill-proportioned, but finely detailed, neoclassical base (1915, Henry J. Hardenbergh), surmounted by an ill-proportioned, but finely detailed, neoclassical tower (1926, Warren and Wetmore) which bears the clock.

At 20 Union Square East (Park Avenue South), at the northeast corner of 15th Street, is the **American Savings Bank**, designed by Henry Bacon and built in 1907. This is a compact building with an incredibly stately porch with four massive Corinthian columns. It is the only major building in New York by Bacon, who designed the Lincoln Memorial (1922) in Washington, D.C., and who was one of America's finest classical architects. At 201 Park Avenue South, at the northeast corner of 17th Street, is the **Guardian Life Insurance Building** of 1911, by D'Oench & Yost. It is a brooding, mansarded affair, exactly the kind of building that should be constructed to wall a square such as Union. Appended to it, at 105 East 17th Street between Park Avenue South and Irving Place, is a Miesian modern annex dating from 1961 and designed by Skidmore, Owings & Merrill.

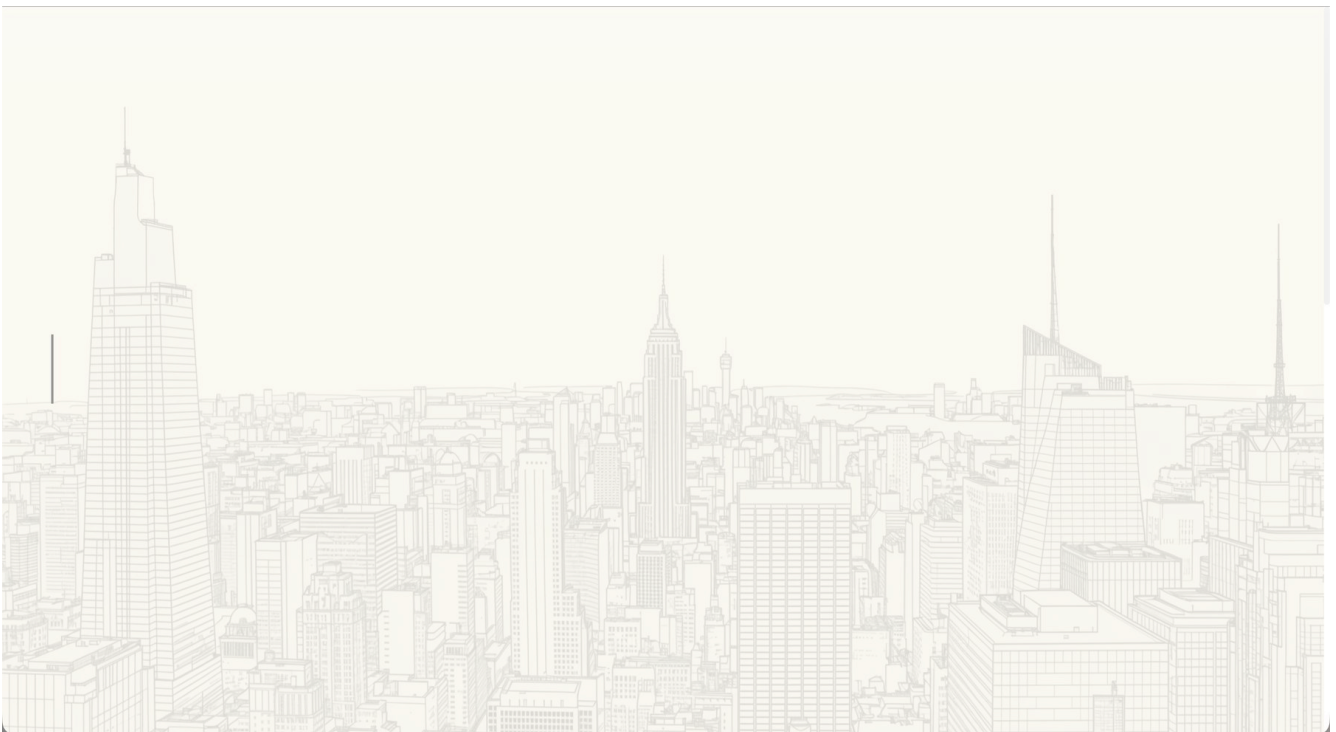
The Century Building, former headquarters of one of the most popular magazines of the nineteenth century, stands at 33 East 17th Street between Park Avenue South and Broadway. Built in 1881 and designed by William Schickel, this red-brick-and-limestone Queen Anne pile comes straight out of Victorian London. It is one of the few extant major Queen Anne buildings in Manhattan; see also the Gramercy apartments (1883, G. W. da Cunha, 8.7) at Gramercy Park, and the former Mercantile Exchange (1884, Thomas R. Jackson, 3.12) in TriBeCa. The former **Bank of the**



Metropolis, designed by Bruce Price, at 31 Union Square West, at the northwest corner of 16th Street, was built in 1903 and is another gem from the perhaps underrated father of Emily Post. Its Union Square

LPC, *Union Square*, 1881, p. 1

Quotes drawn from this page: 8 21 22 23 24 26 27 29 30 31 32 33 34 35 36 39 42 43 44 46 47
48 49 51 52 53 55 56 57 58 59 60

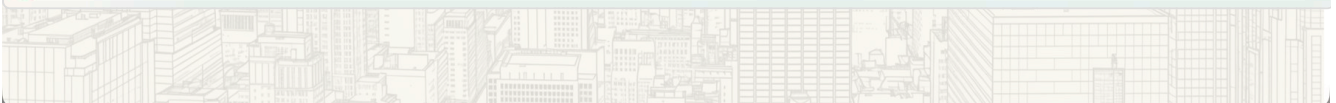


"<Architecture Style>_Queen-Anne, neo-Grec: Secondary Façade 18th Street, <Base Color>_Crystal - 213 213 213, <Façade Color>_Brick Red - 196 47 69, <Base Material>_Red Brick, Wyoming Bluestone, <Façade Material>_Brick, Terra Cotta, Wyoming Bluestone, Iron, <Entrance Description>_3 Bays, Pedimented, Arched, Fanlight, Cast Iron Ornament, Tuscan Pilasters, Console Bracket Capital, <Window Detail>_Segmental Arch Lintel (3-5), Stone Keystone, 2-story Oriel, Window Panes: [1/1] (w/ Transom), <Brickwork Style>_Running Bond, Rusticated Brick Pilasters, Garlands, Shells, Grotesques, Dentil Course, Egg & Dart Course, Swags, <Roofline Description>_Gambrel Roof, Cast Iron Cornice, 2-Story Dormers, Balustrade, Dentils, Frieze, Skew Corbels, Sunflower Terra Cotta Finials."

LPC · (1881) UNION SQUARE · 1881 · P. 1

Mentioned as: "33 East 17th Street"

[View Document Image](#)



Greene, *New York for New Yorkers*, 2001, p. 32

Quotes drawn from this page: 14 69 71



FROM 1881

1880s:
Sweatshops
proliferate,
especially on
the Lower
East Side.
Immigrant
labor is willing

to work long
hours for little
pay.
1882: An
electric
generating
plant opens on
Pearl Street.

Electric street-
lights begin to
replace gas
lights and
lamplighters.
1883: Mr. and
Mrs. W. K.
Vanderbilt hold



Dakota Apartments
1 West 72nd Street

● This eight-story building was one of the first major investments on the Upper West Side. The yellow-brick and terra-cotta Dakota, one of the city's first luxury apartment houses, is an eclectic combination of gables, dormers, and arches embellished with both Gothic and Western motifs. It is surrounded by



President Chester A. Arthur ▲
Madison Square

In **1881**, upon the assassination of President James A. Garfield, Vice President Arthur is sworn in as president at his home, 123 Lexington Avenue. He was the second president to be sworn in in NYC; Washington was the first. **1899**, sculptor, **George Edwin Bissell. FLT**



The Century Building
33 East 17th Street

● Queen Anne-style commercial buildings are rare in NYC. This seven-story Barnes & Noble was once the home of the Century Company, publishers of



a moat and iron rail punctuated with Zeus and sea monsters (detail above). The Dakota was home of the fictitious Si Morley from the book *Time and Again* and of many well-known personalities, including Leonard Bernstein, Roberta Flack, and John Lennon, who was shot at its entrance in 1980. **1881**, Henry J. Hardenbergh. **UWS**

the once popular *Century* and *St. Nicholas* magazines and books by Edith Wharton, Mark Twain, and Rudyard Kipling. **1881**, William Schickel. **FLT**



Sylvan Terrace

Between West 160th and 162nd Streets

Sylvan Terrace is lined with virtually identical two-story wooden houses. The wooden canopies over the doorways are very rare in New York. **1882**, Gilbert Robinson, Jr. **UPM**

Postal & Dolkart, *Guide to New York City Landmarks*, 2009, p. 76

Quotes drawn from this page: 15 28 50 73



MANHATTAN

was designed to attract the attention of riders on the Sixth Avenue Elevated, which ran in front of the building.

195 **5, 7, 9, 17, 19, 21, and 23 West 16th Street** (c. 1845–46), designated individually 1990. In the 1840s the streets adjacent to Fifth Avenue just north of 14th Street were developed with row houses. Most of these structures were demolished as commerce invaded the area in the late 19th century, but West 16th Street retains a significant number of Greek Revival houses. The most impressive are the four survivors of a row of nine wide houses—Nos. 5, 7, 9, and 17—each of which has a full-height curving bay on its front facade, an extremely rare feature in New York. In 1930 the family-planning pioneer Margaret Sanger moved her Birth Control Clinical Research Bureau into No. 17. Nos. 19 and 21 are simpler houses displaying fine ironwork, while No. 23 has a magnificent cast-iron balcony and stoop railing. All the houses have wide stone entrance enframements with battered sides and eared corners; this is a classic Greek form copied from the window surrounds on Greek temples.

197 **Lincoln Building, 1–3 Union Square West** (R. H. Robertson, 1889–90), designated 1988. The Lincoln Building is representative of the early skyscraper form as it evolved in New York, where architects chose to adapt already-popular styles to this new building type. Robertson designed the Lincoln Building in the same Romanesque Revival style that he used for churches, houses, and other structures. The building, faced in limestone, granite, red brick, and terra cotta, marks an important transitional phase in skyscraper engineering: it was constructed with a metal framing in combination with traditional masonry bearing walls.

198 **Bank of the Metropolis, 31 Union Square West** (Bruce Price, 1902–03), designated 1988. Price was an important early skyscraper designer with a particular interest in adapting the tripartite form of the column to tall buildings. This neo-Renaissance limestone-faced example is clearly massed in Price's preferred base-shaft-capital manner. The Bank of the Metropolis, founded in 1871 to serve the needs of businesses in the Union Square area, maintained its offices on the square until 1918, when it was absorbed by the Bank of Manhattan.

199 **Decker Building, now the Union Building, 33 Union Square West** (John Edelmann in the employ of Alfred Zucker, 1892–93), designated 1988. A rare example of a Moorish-inspired skyscraper, the headquarters of the

Decker Piano Company was designed by John Edelmann, mentor and friend of Louis Sullivan. Many features of the Decker Building, most notably the naturalistic ornament, reflect Sullivan's influence. Between 1968 and 1974 Andy Warhol's Factory occupied the sixth floor. The base was handsomely restored in 1995.

200 **Century Building, now Barnes & Noble Bookstore, 33 East 17th Street** (William Schickel, 1880–81), designated 1986. The red brick Century Building is a rare New York example of a Queen Anne-style commercial structure. Erected to house the prestigious Century Publishing Company, publisher of *The Century* and *St. Nicholas* magazines, the building is characteristic of the finest Queen Anne design in its free use of classical motifs in stone and terra cotta and its employment of the style's trademark sunflowers. After standing vacant for many years, the building was converted into a bookstore, and the facade received an award-winning restoration.

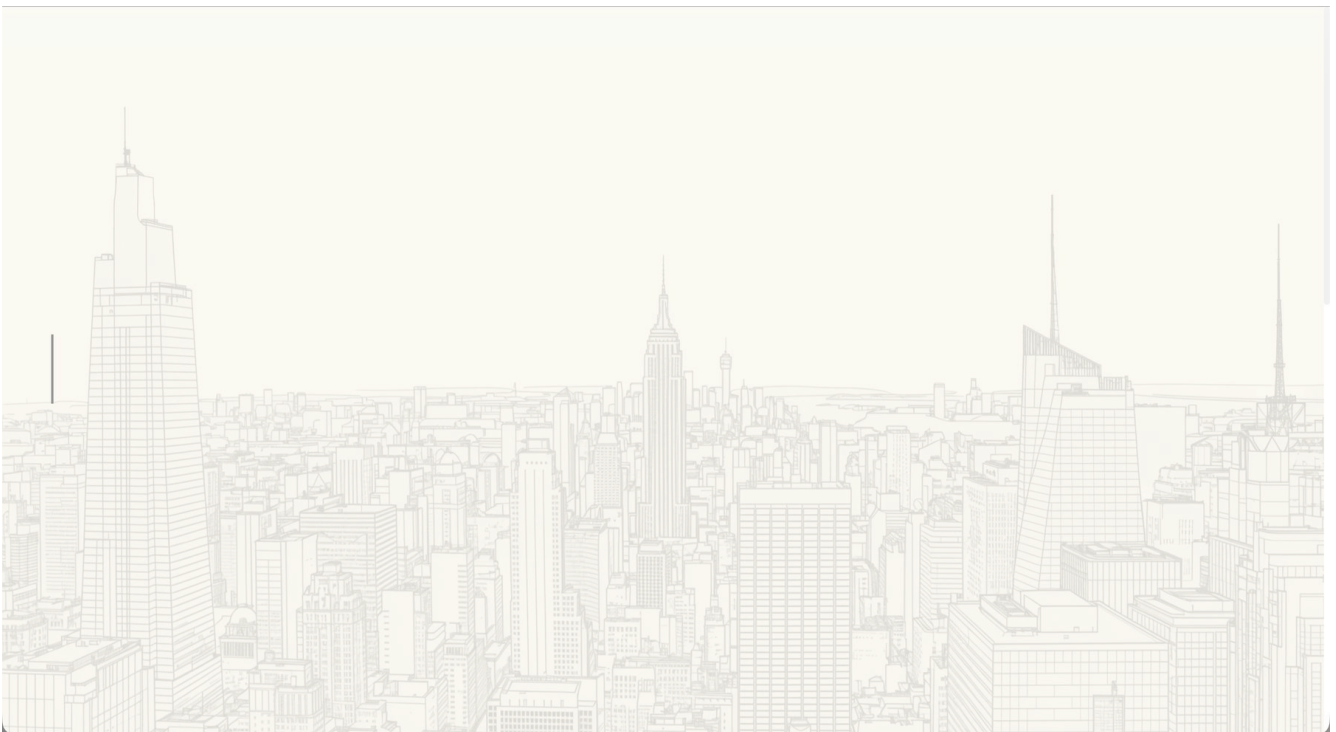
201 **Everett Building, 200 Park Avenue South** (Goldwin Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), designated 1988. Located on the north side of Union Square, the Everett Building exemplifies an important development in the design of commercial high-rise buildings—the construction of functional, fireproof structures with large windows, open floor space, and simple classical detail. This emphasis on functionalism reflects the influence of Chicago skyscraper designs; in fact, the architect, Goldwin Starrett, had worked for four years in the Chicago office of Daniel Burnham.

202 **Gorham Manufacturing Company Building, 809–891 Broadway** (Edward Hale Kendall, 1883–84; alteration, John H. Duncan, 1912), designated 1984. This commercial building in the Queen Anne style was erected for the Gorham Manufacturing Company, a leading American silver firm, for its retail outlet in the exclusive Ladies' Mile shopping district. The Gorham is an early example of a mixed-use building: only the lower two floors were occupied by the store; the upper floors were rented as bachelor apartments. By 1893, however, the building was entirely in commercial use. The architect John H. Duncan is responsible for a remodeling of the building in 1912 that entailed the removal of a corner tower and the addition of roof dormers. The building now contains shops at street level and apartments above.

203 **Lord & Taylor Store, 901 Broadway** (James H. Giles, 1869–70), designated 1977. Two English immigrants, Samuel Lord and George Taylor, founded the dry goods firm

Hennessy, *Walking Broadway*, 2020, p. 96

Quotes drawn from this page: 20 37 40 45 65 82 83



hall to the International Ladies Garment Workers' Union, and it became a major center for union activity. In 1984 the Roundabout Theater Company took over for a decade before heading uptown. The building is now being converted to office and retail use, but the exterior, including the Liberty Cap on the pediment facing Union Square, long a symbol of the society, has been preserved.

846.2

C Century Building

33 East 17th Street

1880–81 · WILLIAM SCHICKEL

96

Warm red brick, crisp bluestone trim, and a two-story oriel window give this Queen Anne style commercial building a welcoming domestic aspect. Richly detailed terra-cotta panels and crisply carved stone surround the ground floor entrance, embellish the facade, and reappear in the treatment of the top floor dormers.



The Century Building was commissioned as a speculative undertaking by the Arnold and Constable families. In addition to their department store, they were among the largest landholders in late nineteenth-century New York. For much of the Century Building's life, it was the home of the celebrated *Century Magazine*.

D Decker Building

844

33 Union Square West

1892–93 · JOHN EDELMANN AND ALFRED ZUCKER

A little bit of Venice, echoes of the Alhambra and Louis Comfort Tiffany, and a large dose of the Chicago School are all brought together here with great panache. Early in his career Edelmänn lived in Chicago where he was a mentor to the young Louis Sullivan. It's easy to spot their shared preference for a highly distinctive and complex style of shallow carved ornament. Here it enriches nearly every flat surface. The designers' underlying inspiration was always rooted in the natural world.



Stern, *New York* 2000, 2006, p. 1140

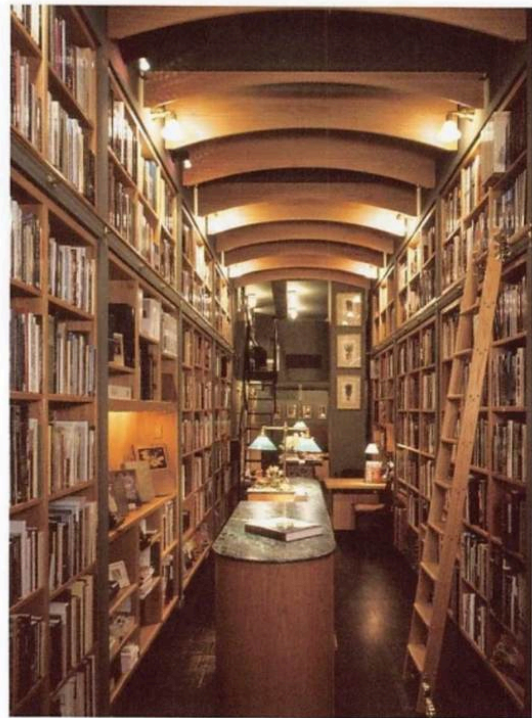
Quotes drawn from this page: 61 62 75 76 77





Rizzoli, 31 West Fifty-seventh Street. Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates, 1986. McGrath. NMcG

significantly, it featured a college library-like study hall with rows of tables overlooking Broadway attracting students and others. Barnes & Noble continued with the high amenity, superstore formula, opening a new 35,000-square-foot store (1994) on the west side of Sixth Avenue between Twenty-first and Twenty-second Streets in the former Adams & Company building (De Lemos & Cordes, 1902).⁹⁰ Also in 1994 Barnes & Noble took over the space formerly occupied by Conran's in Hugh Stubbins's Citicorp Center (1977), opening a 30,000-square-foot store.⁹¹ In 1995 Barnes & Noble transformed the 100,000-square-foot Queen Anne-style Century Building (William Schickel, 1880–81), once home to a famous literary magazine, 33 East Seventeenth Street, facing Union Square.⁹² Judith Saltzman of Li-Saltzman restored the facade, and James Cohen was charged with maintaining the character of the landmark interiors, which were listed on the National Register, while SBLM Architects/By 3 Group designed the bookstore itself in keeping with the bookseller's overall design standards. Taking advantage of the high ceilings and such architectural features as Corinthian capped cast-iron columns and considerable original woodwork, the effect was impressive, even though it lacked the intimacy and charm of many of the traditional bookstores such as Shakespeare & Company and Endicott that the superstores were rapidly driving out of business.⁹³ The soul-searching over the fate of the independent bookstores even reached the point of worrying whether the huge chains, and especially Barnes & Noble, would influence the quality and variety of books written in the increasingly homogenized book business. But the superstores had their defenders (as well as the business of the former customers of the independents). One unlikely ally, Victor Navasky, publisher of the liberal magazine *The Nation*, observed in 1995 in an op-ed article in the *New York Times*: "Twenty years ago, plagiarizing Rousseau, I lamented in print that 'books are born free but they are everywhere in chains.' As bookstore chains get more powerful, I argued, they will drive out independent bookstores and substitute commercial values for literary ones. Yet these days, while giving lip service to the idea of independent shops like Shakespeare & Company . . . I have been buying most of my books from Barnes & Noble. . . . This is partly because . . . too often Shakespeare . . . didn't have the book I needed . . . [and] then there are the superstore amenities: bigger discounts on just-published books, a cafeteria-cum-coffee bar, racks crammed with journals and newspapers from near and far. And there is no harassment about eating or peer pressure to shut up,



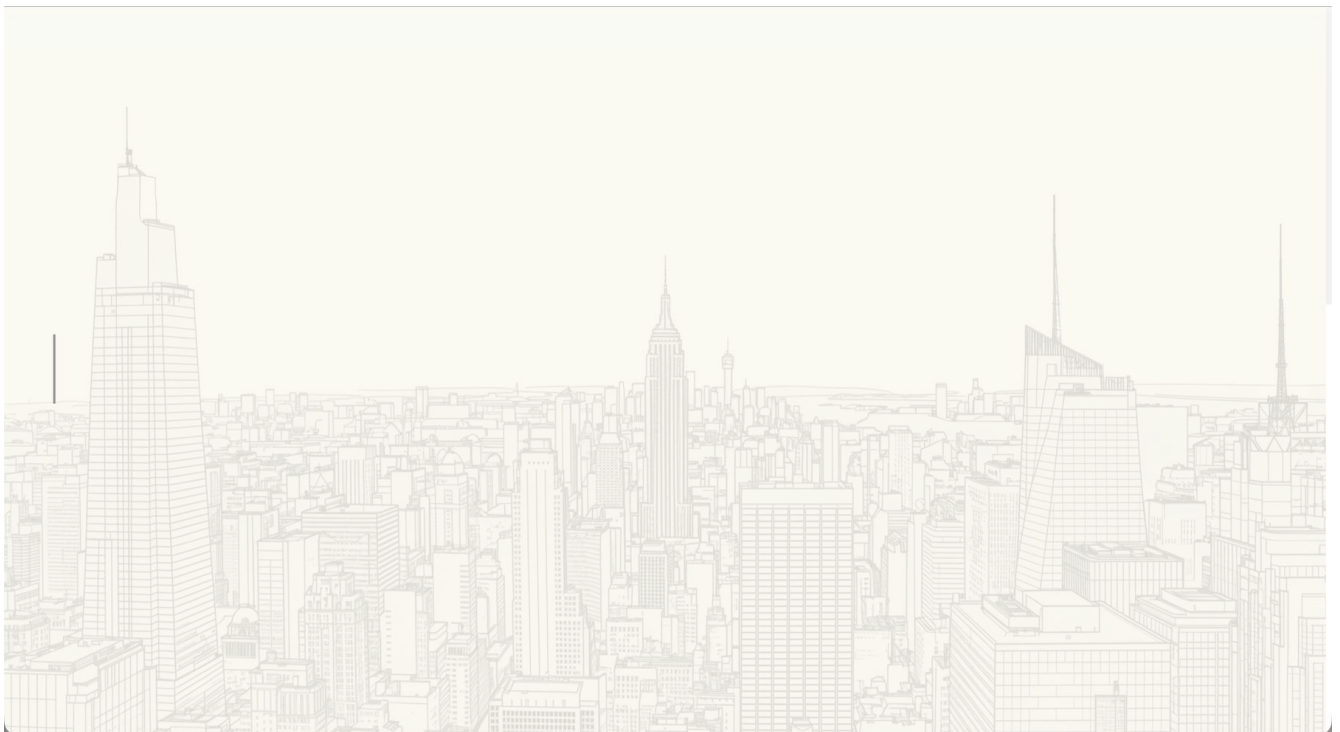
Archivia, 944 Madison Avenue. Michael Rubin, 1992. McGrath. NMcG

as there is in the public library. . . . But what really intrigues me . . . goes beyond yuppie trappings. . . . I am impressed by the fact that at a time when privatization is in the air . . . these chains seem intent on taking private space into the public sphere."⁹⁴ The success of Barnes & Noble spurred competition, and the Borders chain opened two large stores also filled with comfortable chairs and cafés, at Five World Trade Center and 461 Park Avenue, northeast corner of Fifty-seventh Street.⁹⁵ But perhaps the greatest threat to Barnes & Noble, and the whole superstore concept, was the dramatic growth of selling books over the internet, pioneered by Amazon.com but quickly imitated by Borders and Barnes & Noble themselves. By the late 1990s, the boom of large midtown bookstores was a thing of the past, especially on Fifth Avenue, where the only remaining store was Barnes & Noble's branch at 600 Fifth Avenue. Although the city's finest bookselling space in Ernest Flagg's Scribner Building (1913), 597 Fifth Avenue, was closed in 1996, the interior was lost only to books, as the space was reinvented as a retail outlet for the Italian clothing company Benetton (see Fifth Avenue).

A few brave entrepreneurs attempted to counter the superstore trend with smaller shops that offered exceptional levels of service in intimate and fundamentally traditional settings. One of these was the New York arm of the Italian publisher Rizzoli, which in 1985 was forced out of its elegant Fifth Avenue store after twenty-one years of service in order to make way for Kohn Pedersen Fox's 712 Fifth Avenue (see Fifth Avenue). Rizzoli relocated a short distance away at 31 West Fifty-seventh Street (1986) where Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer installed them in what

Byron, *New York Interiors At the Turn of the Century*, 1976, p. 154

Quotes drawn from this page: 63



daylight: the photographer's hands in the lower left corner count off the seconds for holding the pose.

128. OFFICE OF EARL AND WILSON COLLAR MANUFACTURERS, 33 EAST 17TH STREET (1903). A business that rode the crest of fashion, Earl and Wilson was one of a number of makers of men's detachable collars, which were of paper, celluloid or starched cloth. The labyrinth of banistered corrals provided well-defined spaces for executives and employees, and it symbolized a well-ordered bureaucracy. The pilastered screen with leaded colored-glass windows further departmentalized the workers. Electricity has been brought down to the desk lamps. No females are visible in this headquarters of male attire, which enjoyed a lucrative reign until the whim of fashion changed.

129. OFFICE OF THE AMERICAN TYPE FOUNDERS COMPANY, 2 DUANE STREET (1902). The exposed brick walls, the plain piers, the suggestions of steel-and-concrete inner construction, the natural-wood floors, the suspended lighting and the similar tambour desks do not measure up aesthetically to the white-collar office just shown. Nor is the office protocol so firm: the presses to the right and rear indicate that the top staff has a

close affiliation with the production operations of the concern. A single prim secretary breaks the sex rigidity of the staff.

130. GRAND ENTRANCE ON DECK A OF THE *R.M.S. Lusitania* (1907). Built in 1906 for the Cunard Line, the turbine-powered luxury liner was given quiet Classical decoration with a neat elegance of detail. Upholstered, built-in seats to either side of the simplified Adam mantel afforded the coziness of the county-house inglenook, and a porch-like informality is achieved by indiarubber tile floor, uncarpeted, the potted palms, and the wicker chairs and tables. The fireplace abuts the steamer's third funnel hatch, but the flue is not connected.

131. FIRST-CLASS DINING SALOON ON DECK C OF THE *Lusitania* (1907). The upper floor of the two-level first-class dining saloon surrounds the open circular rotunda whose dome is carried on the Roman Ionic columns seen in the background. Small potted palms are table centerpieces in Art Nouveau cachepots. Well-padded chairs swivel for ease in sitting down at or leaving the table. The *Lusitania* was torpedoed by a German submarine off the Irish coast on 7 May 1915. This hostile action against a civilian vessel prompted resentment in America and led to its support of the Allied cause in World War I.

Stern, *New York* 1880, 1999, p. 442

Quotes drawn from this page: 64





753 Broadway, southwest corner of East Eighth Street. J. Morgan Slade, 1880. View to the southwest. LAA. CU.

fact, architects seemed to have been pushed to a higher level of creativity than was typical in downtown buildings, perhaps because of the need for these new structures to fit in with a still fashionable residential neighborhood that was also home to the city's most exclusive shops. At the time of its completion, Griffith Thomas's Domestic Sewing Machine Company Building (1872-73), at the southwest corner of Broadway and Fourteenth Street, was the city's tallest, at 110 feet.¹⁸⁸ Given its prominent location in a still mostly residential area, it stood out as a monument. Thomas's design, consisting of five stories plus an inhabited mansard, was very Parisian, with its pronounced corner tower rising to a steep segmented dome. In contrast, J. Morgan Slade's five-story 753 Broadway (1880), at the southwest corner of Eighth Street, was a severely detailed three-by-five-bay brick and iron cube.¹⁸⁹ William Schickel's Century Company Building (1880-81), facing Union Square at 33 East Seventeenth Street, between Broadway and Fourth Avenue, developed as a speculative venture by the dry-goods company Arnold Constable, was principally leased by the company that gave the building its name, the publishers of the popular *Century Magazine* as well as *St. Nicholas Magazine*, which was written for children.¹⁹⁰ The Century Building was also home to



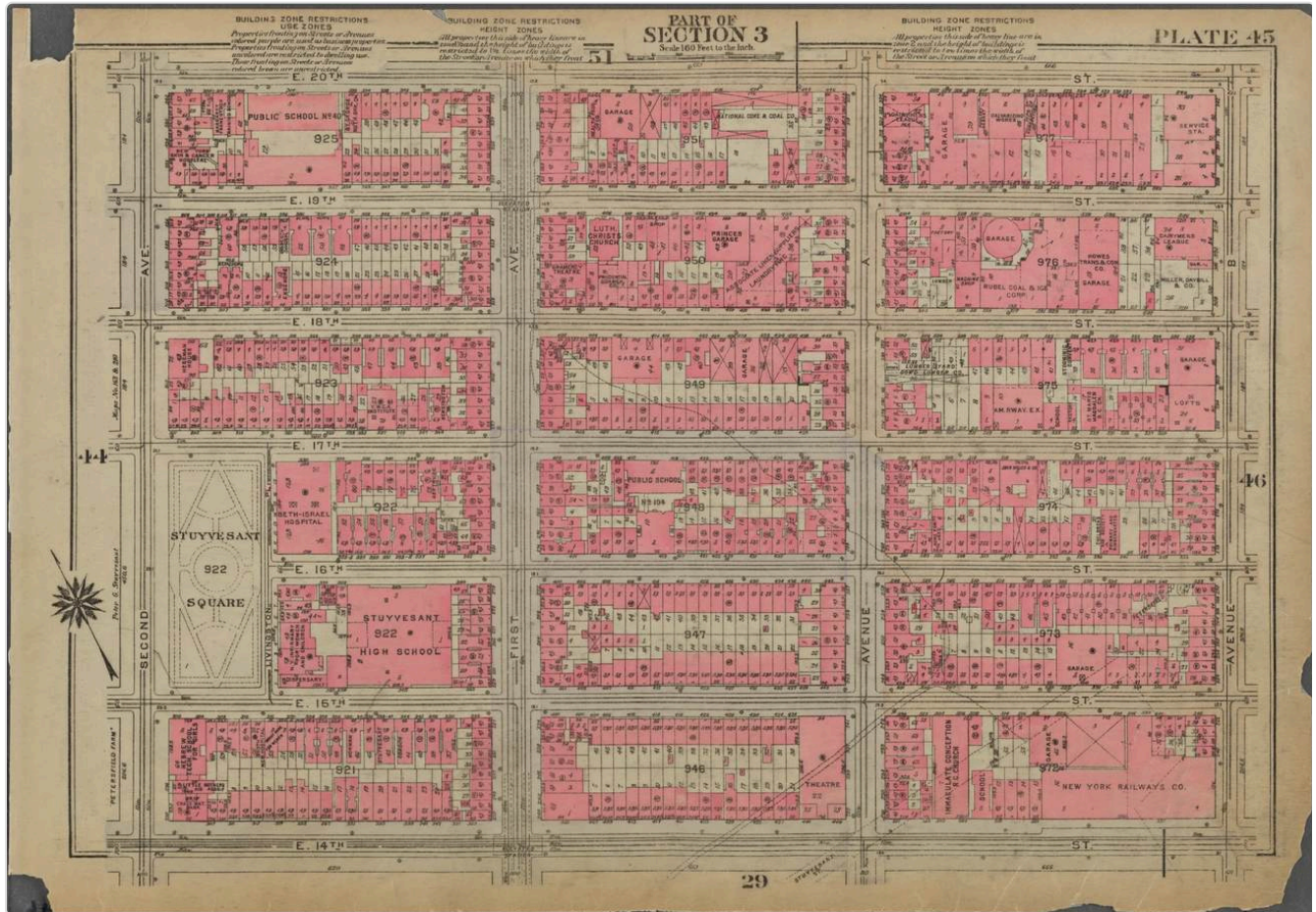
Lincoln Building, northwest corner of Broadway and East Fourteenth Street. R. H. Robertson, 1885. View to the northwest. AR. CU.



McIntyre Building, northeast corner of Broadway and East Eighteenth Street. R. H. Robertson, 1890-92. View to the northeast. King, 1893. CU.

G W Bromley & Co, 1916 Atlas of the Borough of Manhattan, p. 55

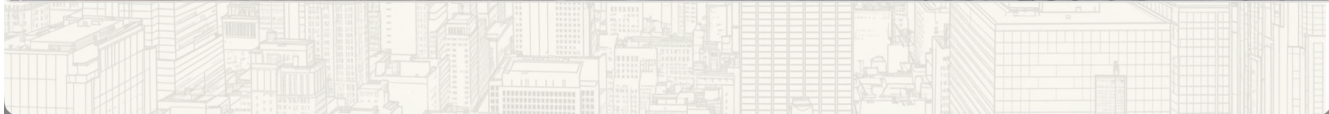
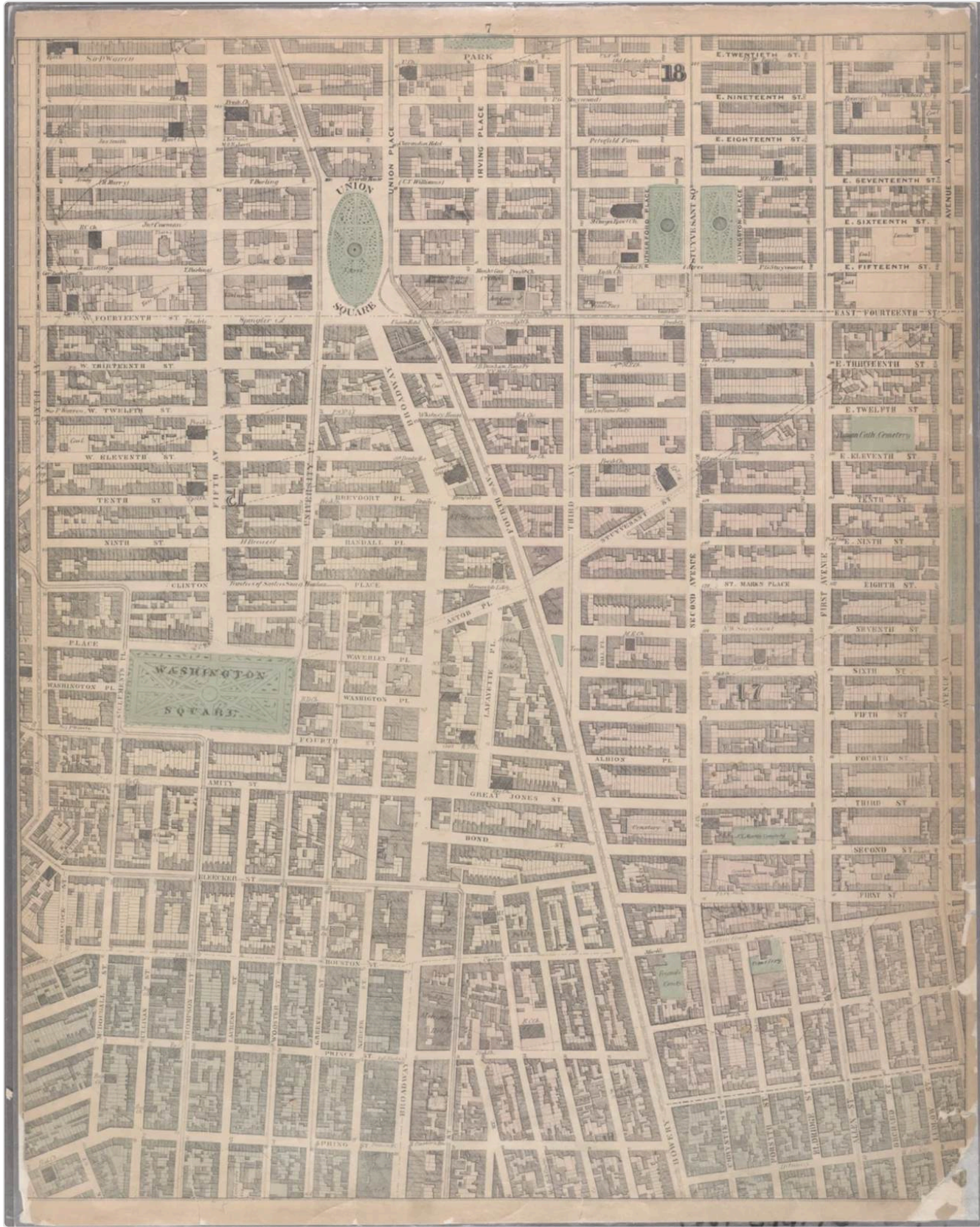
Quotes drawn from this page: 70



Dripps, 1867 *Dripps Plan*, p. 7

Quotes drawn from this page: 72





Stern, *New York 1880, 1999*, p. 440

Quotes drawn from this page: 78

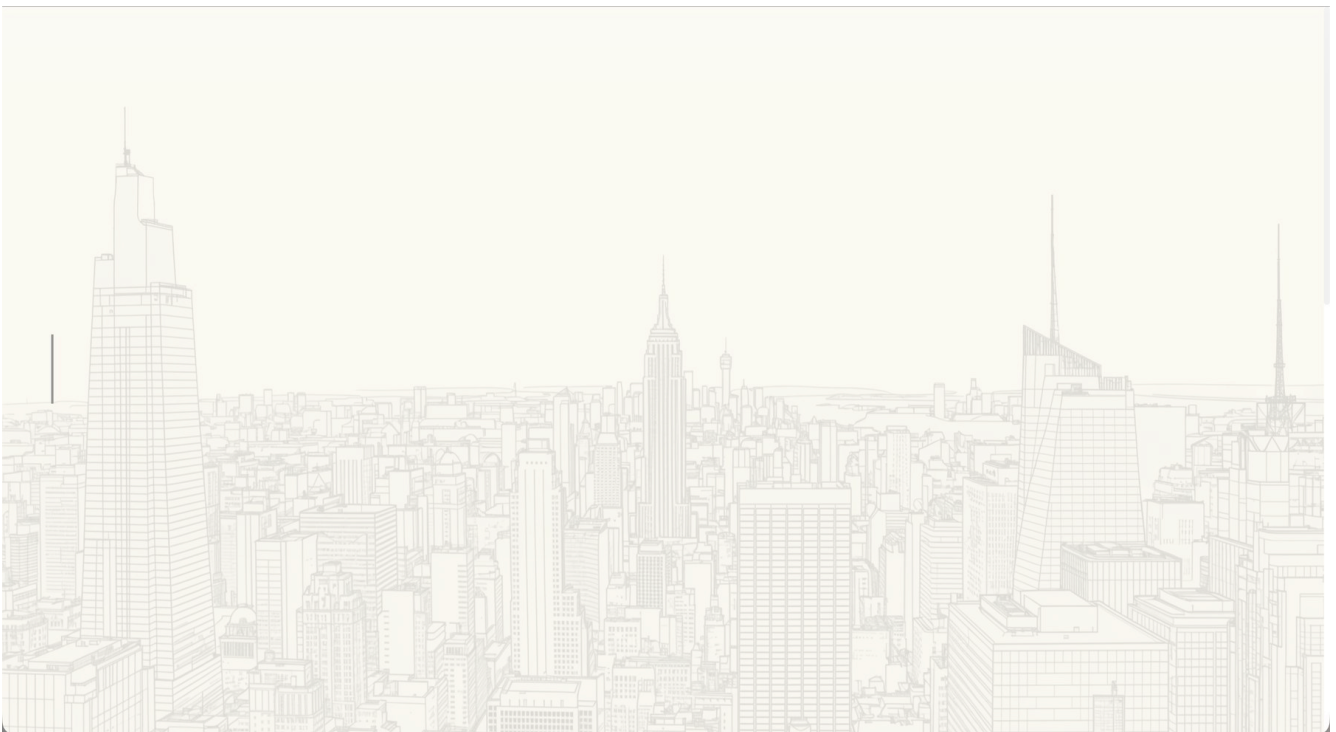




Century Company Building, 33 East Seventeenth Street. William Schickel, 1880–81. View to the northeast showing, from left to right, the Parish Building (Detlef Lienau, 1883–84), Century Company Building, and Everett House (1854). NYHS.

Goldberger, *The City Observed*, 1979, p. 91

Quotes drawn from this page: 79 81



A/UNION SQUARE, STUYVESANT SQUARE, AND THE EAST TWENTIES

II A 1 • UNION SQUARE: Intersection of Park Avenue South and Broadway: 14th to 17th streets

Union Square was named as the joining of the Bowery Road and the Bloomingdale Road (Broadway), the city's main routes early in the nineteenth century. It was an elegant square in the pre-Civil War days, and 14th Street, which forms its southern boundary, was long a theatrical center—once the Academy of Music, the city's most fashionable pre-Metropolitan opera house, was the area's grandest magnet. Later on, into the twentieth century, the square became a center for radical activities, where speech-makers spoke on soapboxes and where protest marches begin.

Union Square's past, be it in either its formal or its Hyde Park Corner incarnation, is more interesting than its present. Now the square is just a dreary park, one of the least relaxing green spaces in Manhattan. The square was redesigned around World War I to accommodate a huge BMT subway station underneath, and the result is ungainly. Nothing, in fact, seems correctly proportioned, from the oddly deep benches to the overall shape of the "square" itself. Like Washington Square, this is too big to be a square, too small to be a good park, although the uneven shape does make this a bit more parklike than Washington Square.

The location of Union Square is unfortunate. Heavy truck and bus traffic on all sides means that the city intrudes aurally as well as visually. Much of the area at the park's edge has been paved for parking, and the surrounding precinct is tawdry with no particular charm. The best buildings

are on the west side (see below), although there are a few of note on the east side.

Most pleasing is the nice four-story mansard roof of the Guardian Life Insurance Company at 201 Park Avenue South (D'Oench & Yost, 1911); it sits comfortably on the square with none of the pretentious fussiness one often finds in elaborate mansards. The addition is by Skidmore, Owings & Merrill, dating from 1961, and while its Miesian style is surprising beside the main building, it comes off—largely, one suspects, because it is low and deferential to the main building in scale, if not in style.

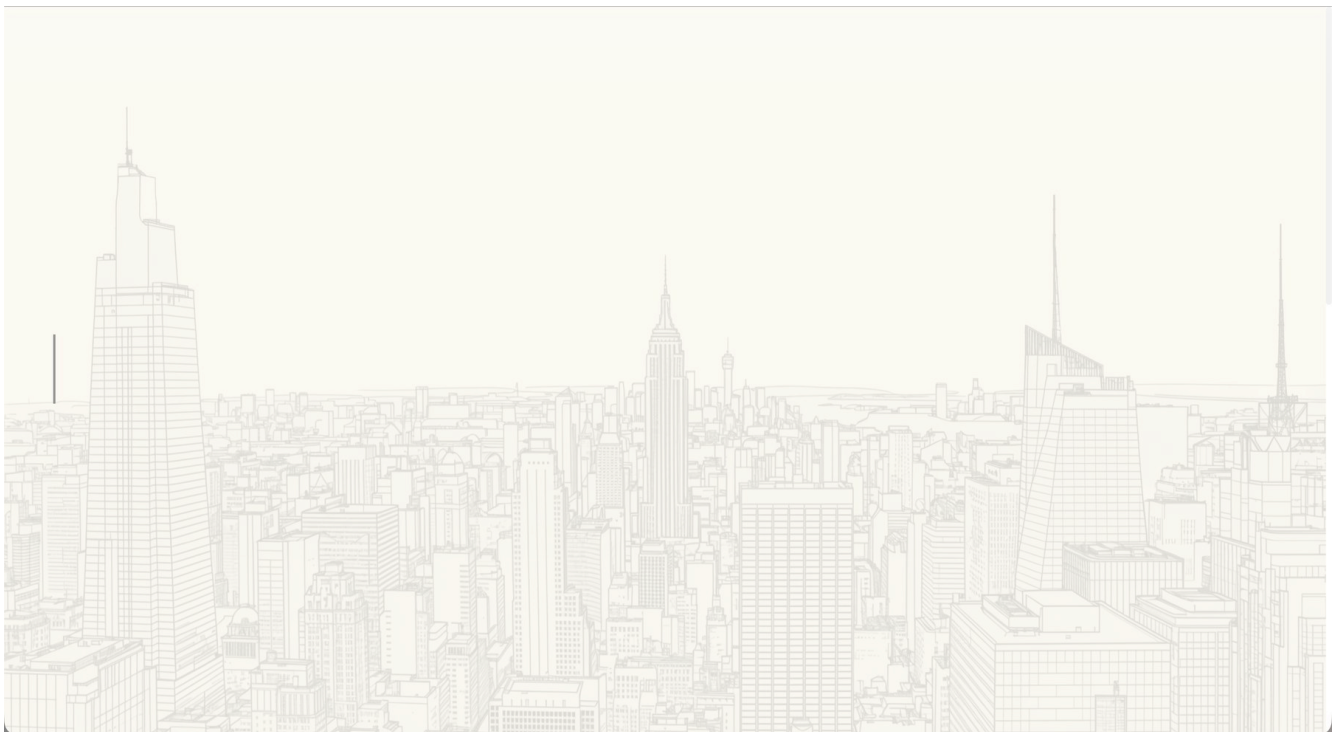
The old Century Building, headquarters of the long-gone *Century Illus-*

33 E 17

A / UNION SQ., STUYVESANT SQ., & EAST TWENTIES • 91

Stern, *New York* 2000, 2006, p. 377

Quotes drawn from this page: 80



a move that was rigorously opposed by the Union Square Community Coalition, a group largely made up of newer residents who had moved into lofts and apartments and feared the impact of real estate speculation on their rented homes. Efforts to rezone Zeckendorf's site coincided with a broader reassessment of the area's zoning, which had been studied in 1979-80 by Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates. Those recommendations formed the basis, in 1984, of the Department of City Planning's proposed special zoning district, intended to encourage mixed-use development on underutilized sites in the park's vicinity, especially Zeckendorf's proposed one-million-square-foot project.¹⁹ Both the district and the Zeckendorf proposal for a twenty-six-story project were approved by the City Planning Commission in November 1984 and by the Board of Estimate in January 1985.²⁰ Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1-3 Union Square West; the Bank of the Metropolis (Bruce Price, 1903), 31 Union Square West; the Century Building (William Schickel, 1881), 33 East Seventeenth Street; the Everett Building (Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), 45 East Seventeenth Street; and the Germania Life Insurance Company Building (D'Oench & Yost, 1911), later the Guardian Life Building, 50 Union Square East.²¹

As built, the four twenty-story towers of Zeckendorf's project, unimaginatively titled Zeckendorf Towers, contained 670 condominium apartments rising above a seven-story base housing 320,000 square feet of offices, an atrium, a much-appreciated supermarket, theaters, and underground parking. Though banal in their detailed design, the scheme of slender, salmon-colored brick-clad towers, each topped by an open-work pyramidal crown—dismissed by the editors of the *AIA Guide* as "illuminated levitating . . . yarmulkes"—minimized shadows on the square and blockage of views from it to the tower of the Consolidated Gas Company Building (Warren & Wetmore, 1926), which they were intended to complement.²² The office floors were entered from Fourth Avenue facing Union Square Park, while the apartments were entered off Fifteenth Street. In its bland uniformity and lock-step regularity, Zeckendorf Towers was hardly inspiring, but it did help the reemerging district turn the economic corner.

While most new construction in the area involved demolition of existing buildings, a through-block parcel that had been vacant since the early 1970s permitted the construction of the twelve-story Genesis Apartments (1995) for ninety-four homeless and low-income families at 113 East Thirteenth Street and an attendant 30,000-square-foot, two-story commercial building at 114 East Fourteenth Street.²³ The project was developed by Housing Enterprise for the Less Privileged (H.E.L.P.), a nonprofit organization founded by Andrew Cuomo, son of New York State Governor Mario Cuomo. As designed by Cooper, Robertson & Partners, the quietly contextual apartment building eschewed all outward signs of social engineering in favor of an expression that many would assume was intended for a much more affluent clientele. Additionally, the building's management program included a program-services staff of fifteen to help the homeless tenants, whose stay was limited to twelve months, make an adjustment back into mainstream society. Genesis provided playgrounds, a day-care center, a basketball court, a library, and a laundry room. Although many in the community were initially opposed to the project, it proved an excellent neighbor.

The retail building on Fourteenth Street, however, was not comparable in quality; its low height, a product of zoning restrictions, contributed to its suburban strip-mall character.

1 Union Square South (1998), designed by Davis, Brody & Associates in association with Schuman, Lichtenstein, Claman & Efron, a twenty-seven-story, 180-unit apartment building atop an eighty-five-foot-high mixed-use retail base that included a fourteen-screen theater, occupied the highly visible 47,500-square-foot full-block site bounded by Fourth Avenue, Thirteenth Street, Broadway, and Fourteenth Street.²⁴ In 1995 the Related Companies had acquired the site from another developer who had cleared it of its buildings, including the historic Union Square Theater (1871; rebuilt, John Terhune and Leopold Eidlitz, 1889), 58 East Fourteenth Street, which had long been obscured behind a huge McDonald's sign.²⁵

Responding to community concerns that this most prominent site might yield yet another business-as-usual apartment house banality, the developers entered into an agreement with the Municipal Art Society to select an architectural firm that would maximize the site's most important attributes, its axial relationship to the vista south along Park Avenue from Grand Central Terminal and its prominent location at the edge of Union Square Park. The society asked two dozen architects to name a firm, besides their own, that they would recommend for the job. From the responses, Related chose three firms to participate in a competition held in 1995: Davis, Brody & Associates, Robert A. M. Stern Architects, and Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates, which later withdrew. Stern proposed an eighteen-story tower on a five-story stone-clad site-filling retail base. The metal-trimmed brick-clad tower was to be set back from the property line to create a strong south terminus for Park Avenue, recalling the campanile-like configuration of Warren & Wetmore's New York Central Building (1929), which, until the construction of the Pan Am Building in 1963, had concluded the axis of Park Avenue on the north side of Grand Central.

Davis, Brody's winning scheme, designed by Steven Davis, son of founding partner Lewis Davis, sought to merge the base with the tower. The initial rendering revealed stylish asymmetrical patterns of windows as well as a deep balcony cut into the north wall. But as built, its blocky mass was pretty banal, the cut reduced to virtual inconsequence, leaving the heavy aesthetic lifting to the work of the artists Kristin Jones and Andrew Ginzel. In a separate competition organized by the Public Art Fund, the two had been chosen to embellish a 100-by-60-foot wall on the building's north facade, between the commercial base and the tower. Jones and Ginzel proposed *Metronome*, confronting the street with a brick wall overlaid with an undulating wavelike pattern of concentric circles and a so-called eye, a four-foot-in-diameter opening that emitted clouds of steam, clearly upstaging the rather tepid facade of the host building. The steam, intended by the artists to recall the geothermal outpouring of Old Faithful, poured forward twice a day, at noon and at midnight, as part of the artists' intention to examine time itself. Each emission was enhanced by the sounding of a long, tapered horn intended to echo the passage of time. A digital clock on the left side of the wall augmented the frequent movements of the city by simultaneously counting and subtracting the hours of the day, with the converging digits in the middle absorbed by a blur of activity, intended to suggest the present.

